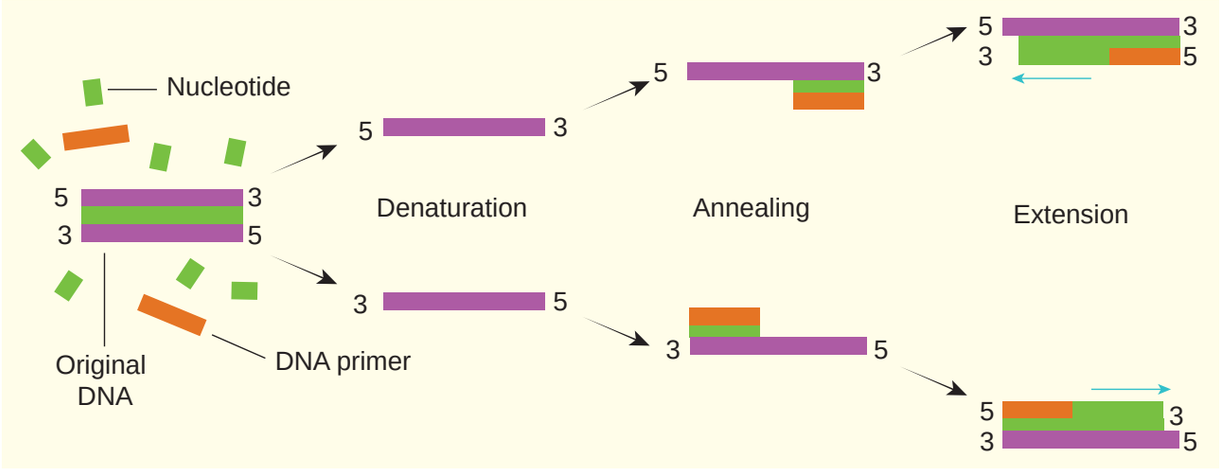


Fig. 9.6 Steps involved in PCR

PCR In Clinical Diagnosis

The specificity and sensitivity of PCR is useful for the diagnosis of inherited disorders (genetic diseases), viral diseases, bacterial diseases, etc., The diagnosis and treatment of a particular disease often requires identifying a particular pathogen. Traditional methods of identification involve culturing these organisms from clinical specimens and performing metabolic and other tests to identify them. The concept behind PCR based diagnosis of infectious diseases is simple – if the pathogen is present in a clinical specimen its DNA will be present. Its DNA has unique sequences that can be detected by PCR, often using the clinical specimen (for example, blood, stool, spinal fluid, or sputum) in the PCR mixture. PCR is also employed in the prenatal diagnosis of inherited diseases by using chorionic villi samples or cells from amniocentesis. Diseases like sickle cell anemia, β-thalassemia and phenylketonuria can be detected by PCR in these samples. cDNA from PCR is a valuable tool for diagnosis and monitoring retroviral infections e.g., Tuberculosis by *Mycobacterium tuberculosis.*

Several virally induced cancers, like cervical cancer caused by Papilloma virus can be detected by PCR. Sex of human beings and live stocks, embryos fertilized *invitro* can be determined by PCR by using primers and DNA probes specific for sex chromosomes. PCR technique is also used to detect sex-linked disorders in fertilized embryos.

Applications of PCR

The differences in the genomes of two different organisms can be studied by PCR. PCR is very important in the study of evolutions, more specifically phylogenetics. As a technique which can amplify even minute quantities of DNA from any source, like hair, mummified tissues, bones or any fossilized materials.

PCR technique can also be used in the field of forensic medicine . A single molecule of DNA from blood stains, hair, semen of an individual is adequate for amplification by PCR. The amplified DNA is used to develop DNA fingerprint which is used as an important tool in forensic science. Thus, PCR is very useful for identification of criminals. PCR is also used in amplification of specific DNA segment to be used in gene therapy.

9.5 Transgenic Animals

In early days selective breeding methods were carried out to improve the genetic characteristics of live stock and other domestic animals. With the advent of modern biotechnology it is possible to carry

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